of their populations are not within protected areas. They are either in reserved forests or in human-dominated habitat." The key takeaway from these sessions was the need for a landscape approach in conservation and going beyond short-term initiatives such as trenches and barricades to fence in wildlife.

Meanwhile, in the session, 'How to Clean up Bengaluru', experts outlined the big challenges facing the city, saying it needs a governance overhaul if it has to deliver on the infrastructural revamp required to keep pace with its rapid growth. The key takeaways from the discussion included: the urgent need to bring in a new planning paradigm given that a clutch of parastatals—which are in charge of providing civic amenities in Bengaluru such as transport, water supply, power, waste management—currently work in silos; the need to push people towards mass rapid transit systems so as to reduce the dependence on personal vehicles; invest in an integrated urban water management system by strengthening the Bengaluru Water Supply and Sewerage Board; and give more teeth to the city's climate action cell in order to implement the action plan that has been drawn up. The conclave also featured eco-warriors working in the areas of decentralised waste management and restoration of lakes and water bodies.

Khandre said that 153 acres of land in Bengaluru's peripheral areas is being developed into a lung space which, when fully developed, will contribute to carbon sequestration. Though Karnataka has 43,000 sq. km of forests, there are 16 districts where the forest cover is less than 10 per cent, Khandre said, noting that the forest department planted 54.8 million saplings across the state in 2023 and 30 million in 2024.

"Sustainable development is not an isolated concept," agreed Khandre. "Any good sustainability model of today should include a mitigation plan to combat climate change, a plan for conservation of natural resources, a plan to promote eco-friendly practices and to drive innovation." As the experts put it, it has to be taken up with alacrity. ■

–Ajay Sukumaran



A.S. PONNANNA
MLA, Virajpet

"The area of conflict is expanding.... We must look at policy decisions that go beyond just creating boundaries. Coexistence is an area we can work on"

LIVING WITH THE WILD: PREPARING FOR A

ARITRA KSHETTRY
National Lead for Elephant Conservation, WWF-India



"If conservation efforts are to be sustained, local communities must be at the centrestage...they are the people actually sharing space with wildlife and bearing the brunt of conservation goals"

RAVI CHELLAM
Wildlife Biologist and Conservation Scientist, CEO, Metastring Foundation



"We have to take a landscape approach. The average size of a protected area is too small to hold viable populations of most of our large mammal species"